

The Only Names That Carry Weight

You do NOT need to be a citation machine. In an informal chat, a name you can't back up is a trap — drop it and the tutor says "go on," and now you're exposed. Learn these six as IDEAS first; the name is just a label you can attach if it comes up naturally. If you forget every name and still explain the ideas, you score well.

The six that actually matter

1. Sparrow — *the examiner; learn this one properly*

The idea: autonomous weapons ("killer robots") are wrong for two reasons. (1) **Responsibility gap** — when the machine kills wrongly, no one can be fairly blamed (not the programmer, commander, or machine), and a killing no one can answer for is illegitimate. (2) **Respect** — being killed by a machine that "decided" to kill you fails to honour you as a person. He's also uneasy about **risk-free, asymmetric war** (drones). **Use it like:** *"Sparrow's worry is that with a killer robot, no one's actually responsible for the death — and that's a basic requirement of fighting justly."* **Why it matters:** it's his field and the climax of the unit. Know it cold.

2. Arkin — *the other side of the robot debate (you need both)*

The idea: robots could be **more** ethical than humans — no fear, rage, or revenge, the emotions behind atrocities. A well-built machine ("ethical governor") might follow the rules of war *better* than a panicked soldier. If they kill fewer civilians, refusing to build them is the immoral choice. **Use it like:** *"Arkin's reply is that robots don't panic or seek revenge, so they might actually kill fewer civilians — and then Sparrow has to explain why that's still not enough."* **Why it matters:** it's the consequentialist counter to Sparrow. Holding both = you understand Move 2 and Move 4 at once.

3. Walzer — *the "standard" just war picture*

The idea: war is justified as **self-defence** against aggression (a state defending itself like a person defending their life — *Rodin attacks exactly this analogy; see the "recognise" list below*). And the **moral equality of combatants** — every soldier may kill enemy soldiers, regardless of whose cause is just; they face each other as equals. **Use it like:** *"The traditional Walzer view is that all soldiers are moral equals — but that's exactly what the revisionists attack."* **Why it matters:** he's the baseline everyone else argues against. Useful as the "common-sense view" you can then complicate.

4. McMahan — *the revisionist who blows up the comfortable picture*

The idea: what makes you a legitimate target isn't your *uniform* — it's your **moral responsibility for an unjust threat** (this is "liability"). So a soldier fighting an *unjust* war is more like an armed robber than an honourable equal. This **rejects** Walzer's moral equality of combatants. **Use it like:** *"McMahan says it's responsibility, not the uniform, that makes you a target — which means the soldiers on the unjust side don't really have a right to kill."* **Why it matters:** it's the single sharpest

idea in the foundations half, and it feeds straight into the drone/robot question of "who's a legitimate target?"

5. Primoratz — *what terrorism actually is*

The idea: terrorism = **deliberate violence against innocents** to terrorise or coerce a wider group. It's condemned because it directly attacks the civilian/combatant line (Move 3). He also argues civilian immunity is about **responsibility**. **Use it like:** *"On Primoratz's definition, the wrong of terrorism is that it targets the innocent on purpose — which is the one line the rules of war exist to protect."* **Why it matters:** gives you a crisp, defensible definition of terrorism — and a neat link back to the distinction principle. (Counter to have ready — **Held:** judge terrorism by the same standard as war; since war kills innocents too, terrorism isn't *automatically* worse.)

6. Nagel — *the cleanest statement of the master key*

The idea: "War and Massacre" sets up the core clash directly — **absolutism** (some acts, like deliberately attacking the innocent, are forbidden no matter the consequences) vs **utilitarianism** (only the outcomes matter). Plus limits on *whom* you may attack and *how*. **Use it like:** *"Nagel frames it as absolutism versus utilitarianism — which is really the question under this whole topic: do the ends justify the means?"* **Why it matters:** he's the name to attach to Move 2 itself. Drop him when you want to signal you see the deep structure.

Names to recognise — but never force

If the tutor raises one, here's the one-liner. Don't volunteer them; don't let a blank on a name derail you.

- **Rodin** — national self-defence isn't really like individual self-defence (defending a *country* against bloodless takeover protects institutions, not lives — so the usual justification for war is shakier than it looks).
- **Tolstoy** — pacifism: war is never justified; violence corrupts every cause.
- **Anscombe** — *attacks* pacifism: calling all killing "murder" erases the vital line between killing a soldier and murdering an innocent, which can actually excuse atrocity. Defends the just-war view + double effect.
- **Ward Wilson** — nuclear deterrence may not even *work*: Hiroshima may not have caused Japan's surrender (the Soviet invasion did). If the consequentialist case is factually shaky, the whole justification wobbles.
- **Byman (for) vs Boyle (against)** — drones: precise and life-saving, *or* counter-productive because civilian deaths radicalise and create more enemies ("blowback").
- **Annan (for) vs Coady (against)** — humanitarian war / "Responsibility to Protect": sovereignty is no shield for atrocity, *or* "humanitarian" is too easily a cover for power politics.
- **Morgenthau / Bacevich** — realism: morality doesn't govern international affairs; states pursue power and survival.

The honest rule on names

One *correct* name, genuinely understood, dropped at the right moment = strong. Five names half-remembered = you'll get caught. When in doubt, **explain the idea and skip the name** — the idea is what's marked.